TAMBAPANNI

A History Without Borders

Reconstructing the Identity of the Island Known Today as Sri Lanka
Free from Post-Westphalian Projection and Colonial Epistemic Framing

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> *Someone who knows only one country knows no country.*
>
> *— Seymour Martin Lipset, Continental Divide (1990)*[1]

> *We have met the enemy and he is us.*
>
> *— Walt Kelly, through Pogo, Earth Day Poster (1970)*[2]

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I. Methodological Preamble

> ***A Note on the Name.*** *Tambapanni is used throughout this document as a philosophical and historical designation, not as a prescription for renaming the modern state. It names what the island was before the colonial and nationalist epistemologies that this paper analyses were imposed upon it. It names a place whose identity was connective rather than exclusive, riverine rather than bounded, Sanskrit-oceanic rather than ethnically fixed. To call the island Tambapanni in this context is to insist on identifying what it was before it was made into what it is now told to have always been. It is an act of historiographic honesty, not political prescription. The author has no position on what the modern state should call itself. That is for its people to decide, freely, once the manufactured foundations of the current division are understood.*

Every history is written through a lens. The question is whether the historian acknowledges the lens. The dominant historiography of the island known today as Sri Lanka, in antiquity Tambapanni to its earliest inhabitants, Taprobane to Greek and Roman traders, Serendib to Arab navigators, has been written through three overlapping lenses that systematically distort the evidence: the post-Westphalian nation-state framework, the Germanic Aryan philological tradition, and the colonial administrative need for fixed ethnic categories.

This document does not claim to be free of perspective. It makes its perspective explicit, and follows two foundational principles: that the political problems of the island cannot be resolved without understanding the false historical foundation on which they have been built; and that understanding that foundation requires a framework for what a modern democratic state actually requires, and why the island has never had one.

What a Modern Democratic State Actually Requires

A modern democratic state rests on three institutional pillars: an effective and impartial state apparatus; the rule of law that binds even the most powerful actors; and democratic accountability through which citizens hold the state to account.[3,5]

The critical word is impartial. A state apparatus is impartial when it serves all citizens equally regardless of ethnicity, religion, language, or lineage: when its bureaucrats, judges, police, and military are recruited on merit and bound by rules rather than by loyalty to a particular community. This is what distinguishes a modern state from a patronage network.[3]

A state founded on a racial or religious ethos, on the principle that one ethnic or religious group is the primary or rightful custodian of the state, structurally cannot achieve this impartiality. The founding principle itself designates who the state serves. Every institution built on that principle carries the designation forward. Minority communities are then not citizens of a shared state but subjects of someone else's state, at best tolerated, at worst excluded.[3]

The Fukuyama sequencing failure is not an abstract proposition. It has a precise historical test case. When democratic competition arrives before an impartial state exists, the question that every election answers is not "which programme will serve all citizens best" but "which constituency will the state serve next." What does it mean

when a newly independent state's first major legislative act narrows the definition of who the state is for? A rational observer examining the structural consequences of the Sinhala Only Act of 1956, the displacement of Tamil civil servants, the restriction of university entrance by language, the progressive contraction of the state's impartiality, would be compelled to conclude that what was at stake was not language policy. It was the definition of citizenship itself. And that conclusion was not the product of malice. It was the mathematically predictable output of a democratic system operating without the impartial institutional architecture that would have constrained what a majority could do with its majority.

The deeper problem is that racial and religious ethos in state-founding principles is incompatible with the rule of law itself. The rule of law requires that law bind all equally, including the state. A state whose founding principle designates a preferred community cannot be genuinely bound by law when law conflicts with that designation. The designation will always override the law, through legislation if possible, through communal pressure if necessary.[4]

Sri Lanka Democratized Before It Built a Strong, Impartial State

Fukuyama's analysis of political sequencing establishes that the order in which state institutions develop has profound consequences for their eventual character.[3]

The correct developmental sequence is: first, a strong and impartial state apparatus; second, the rule of law constraining that apparatus; third, democratic accountability enabling citizens to direct the apparatus. Countries that followed this sequence, Prussia, Japan, South Korea, developed bureaucracies with their own professional character, resistant to capture by particular factions.[3]

Countries that democratized before building a strong impartial state faced a different outcome. When popular elections arrive before a professional, meritocratic, rule-following bureaucracy exists, the state apparatus becomes a prize of democratic competition. Politicians winning elections distribute state employment, contracts, and resources to their supporters. The state is not impartial; it is clientelist. It serves whoever wins the election, not the citizenry as a whole.[3]

> *When popular democratization precedes the development of a strong, autonomous administrative state, the executive branch is captured as a prize of clientelism.*[3]

This is precisely the trajectory of Sri Lanka. Universal suffrage was introduced in 1931 under the Donoughmore Constitution, before independence, before a professional state apparatus existed, before the rule of law had been established as genuinely binding on political actors.[5,30]

The result was that democratic competition immediately became a competition for ethnic patronage. Political parties competed by offering ethnic constituencies what they wanted, not because ethnic division was the underlying reality, but because ethnic identity was the available mobilising vehicle in the absence of a civic, impartial state framework to compete within.[5]

The Sinhala Only Act of 1956, the communal riots of 1958, the constitutional removal of minority protections in 1972, the systematic marginalisation of Tamil civil servants and university entrants: these were not failures of democracy. They were the logical outputs of a democratic system operating without an impartial state to constrain what democracy could do. Majorities could use democratic institutions to serve majority interests because there was no strong impartial state standing between democratic outcomes and their implementation.[5]

The consequence is the central problem this document identifies: the problems of Tambapanni will never be resolved if they continue to be approached as a conflict between two ancient communities with irreconcilable identities. They are a structural problem of state formation: a state that was handed democratic machinery before it

had been built as an impartial institution, and that was then captured by an ethnic nationalist project that made impartiality structurally impossible.

The historical analysis that follows is therefore not purely academic. Understanding that the two communities were not ancient enemies, that they were one civilisation whose division was manufactured, is the necessary precondition for understanding what the state of Tambapanni would need to become in order to function as a genuine modern democracy: impartial, civic, and prior to ethnicity in its institutional logic.[3,5]

The Lens Problem

Political and social organisation in pre-modern societies operated on fundamentally different logics than those we assume today.[4]

Sovereignty was personal and dynastic, not territorial. Boundaries were fluid, seasonal, and negotiated, not fixed and defended. Loyalty was to a person, a lineage, or a ritual tradition, not to a geographic unit we would recognise as a nation-state. When we say 'South Indian invasion of Tambapanni,' we commit a category error as profound as saying 'Vijaya invaded Tambapanni.' If one is a migration or a founding, so is the other. The asymmetry in how we apply the word invasion is not a historical judgement; it is a political one, imported from the 20th century.

II. Sources and Their Limitations

Before any analysis of the Vijaya origin question or the Mahavamsa's institutional context can proceed, the nature and limitations of the available sources must be established. Readers unfamiliar with the source criticism summarised here should consult it before proceeding, as it qualifies every claim made in subsequent sections.

The Translation Chain

The primary source for the Vijaya origin narrative is the Mahavamsa, a chronicle compiled in Pali by the monk Mahanama in the 5th or 6th century AD. No undisputed autograph manuscript of the Mahavamsa exists. The text is known through manuscript traditions copied by Sri Lankan Buddhist monasteries over many centuries.[6]

The first English translation was produced by George Turnour in 1837, published as The Mahawanso by Cotta Church Mission Press, Ceylon.[7]

Critically, contemporary accounts record that Turnour knew no Pali when he began his work. He relied on Buddhist monks as intermediaries over a ten-year research period. These intermediaries brought their own institutional perspectives, almost certainly Mahavihara perspectives, to the translation process. Turnour's 1837 text therefore carries not only his own colonial geographic imagination but the interpretive choices of his monastic informants.[7]

The Government of Ceylon subsequently commissioned Wilhelm Geiger to produce a revised translation. Geiger's 1912 edition, published by the Pali Text Society (PTS), founded in London in 1881, is the standard scholarly reference.[6]

Geiger's preface explicitly describes his work as a correction of Turnour. However, Geiger operated within the Germanic Aryan philological framework of his era, a tradition that classified languages and peoples in racial hierarchy terms. His interpretive framework was not neutral, and his footnotes carry assumptions that must be read critically rather than accepted as authoritative.[8]

The full mediation chain is therefore: original Pali manuscripts (not directly accessible to most researchers) → Geiger's 1912 corrected translation → modern historiography. Turnour's 1837 translation fed the earlier popular and

nationalist historiography. At no point in this chain is unmediated access to the original Pali established for non-specialist readers.

The Dipavamsa

The Dipavamsa is an earlier Pali chronicle, predating the Mahavamsa. Hermann Oldenberg produced its critical scholarly edition in 1879.[9]

The Dipavamsa is in overall character less supernaturally elaborated than the Mahavamsa. It omits Kuveni and other yaksha supernatural elements that the Mahavamsa includes. Both texts use the word sīha, lion, in describing the ancestor of Vijaya. The claim sometimes found in secondary literature that the Dipavamsa describes a human bandit named Sinha rather than a lion is a modern scholarly interpretive tradition based on the meaning of the word Sinha, not an explicit textual difference present in Oldenberg's Pali edition. Secondary sources must be distinguished from primary text on this point.[9]

The Mahavamsa as Institutional Document

The Mahavamsa was authored by Mahavihara monks and reflects Mahavihara institutional interests. It was written in Pali, a liturgical language inaccessible to ordinary people in 5th century Anuradhapura. It was never intended as a popular history. It was institutional correspondence within a learned priestly and royal elite.[6,20]

No independent contemporary external source, not Fa-xian's account of around 400 AD, not any epigraphy, not any Chinese, Roman or Puranic record, corroborates the Vijaya founding narrative as historical event. Fa-xian describes both Mahavihara and Abhayagiri as flourishing institutions without characterising either as orthodox or deviant.[10]

The Mahavamsa's claim to Theravada orthodoxy is self-designation. It exists primarily in documents Mahavihara itself produced. The archaeological evidence shows Abhayagiri was larger than Mahavihara at several points, which materially contradicts the narrative of marginal heterodoxy.[11]

III. Period-Specific Definitions

The following definitions apply strictly to the periods under examination. They are not permanent categories. They describe what these terms meant in their specific historical contexts, not what they have subsequently been made to mean.

Pre-3rd Century BC: The Palk Strait Zone

Territory	A zone of seasonal habitation, fishing, and cultivation. Not bounded, not defended as a permanent unit. The sea between the island and the mainland was a highway, not a border.
People	Continuous human populations moving fluidly across what we now call South India and Tambapanni. The Yaksha and Naga peoples mentioned in the Mahavamsa were likely Dravidian-speaking communities of this integrated zone.
Sovereignty	Personal and ritual. A king controlled people and tribute, not fixed geography. Authority extended as far as military reach and marriage alliances, and no further.[4]

3rd Century BC (Before Christ) -- 5th Century AD (Anno Domini): The Anuradhapura Period

State	A ritual and administrative centre with surrounding agrarian territory. Not a nation. Not ethnically exclusive. Anuradhapura at its height was cosmopolitan: Tamil, Sinhala, Pali, Sanskrit, and the languages of traders from Rome, Persia, and China all present simultaneously.[10]
Buddhism	A pan-Indic monastic and philosophical tradition, not an ethnic identity marker. Tamil communities in the north practiced Buddhism alongside Hindu traditions. Abhayagiri hosted Mahayana and Vajrayana traditions with strong South Indian and Central Asian connections.[11]
Sinhalese	Not yet an ethnic category in the modern sense. A linguistic and dynastic designation: people associated with the Sinhala-speaking court tradition. Fluid at the edges and overlapping with Tamil-speaking populations.
Tamil	A classical literary and ritual tradition and spoken language of the northern regions and trading communities. Not yet an ethnic exclusivist category and not politically opposed to Sinhala identity in this period.[12]

5th Century AD: The Mahavamsa Moment

Mahavihara	A major monastic complex in Anuradhapura and the institutional author of the Mahavamsa. It claimed Theravada orthodoxy, a self-designation not corroborated by independent contemporary sources. Archaeological evidence shows Abhayagiri was larger at several points, contradicting any narrative of Mahavihara primacy as settled fact.[6,11]
Abhayagiri	The cosmopolitan monastic complex in Anuradhapura, founded 2nd century BC. Hosted Mahayana, Vajrayana, and Tamil Buddhist traditions. Received patronage from Tamil-associated kings. The real institutional target of Mahavamsa's narrative construction.[11]
Mahavamsa	A monastic institutional legitimacy document written in Pali by Mahavihara monks. Not a popular history. Not a nationalist manifesto. A scholarly-priestly instrument designed to establish Mahavihara's interpretive monopoly over Buddhism and its claim to exclusive royal patronage, against the rival claims of Abhayagiri.[6]

IV. The Sanskrit Indian Ocean World

Before examining the Vijaya origin question, the civilisational context within which the naming conventions of that narrative operated must be established. The founding mythology of Tambapanni does not belong to a single event or a single culture. It belongs to a 1800-year tradition of Sanskrit political naming that radiated across the entire Indian Ocean world, and understanding that tradition is the necessary frame for reading any specific instance within it.

The Śrī Prefix

Sanskrit Śrī is among the oldest political honorifics in any language. It appears in the Rigveda, one of the oldest surviving texts in the Indo-European family, where it denotes the auspicious radiance that attends divine presence: prosperity made visible, sovereignty made legitimate. By the time the Sanskrit cosmological framework had spread across the Indian Ocean world, Śrī had acquired a precise political function. To apply it to a kingdom's name was not description but declaration. It was a claim, addressed to every literate political actor in the connected world, that this polity participated in the Sanskrit sacred-political order. Sri Lanka means Auspicious Lanka. Srivijaya means Auspicious Victory. The prefix did not describe geography. It consecrated polity.[13]

What does it reveal about the nature of this prefix that kingdoms with no ethnic, linguistic, or religious connection to one another all reached for it to mark their sovereignty? Srivijaya was a Malay maritime empire centred in Sumatra. The four kings who presided over the Kandyan kingdom at its height, Sri Vijaya Rajasinha, Kirti Sri Rajasinha, Sri Rajadhi Rajasinha, Sri Vikrama Rajasinha, were Telugu Hindus from Madurai. The Buddha whose tradition gave the Kandyan kingdom its deepest institutional legitimacy is titled Śrī Siddhartha. Vishnu, central to the Hindu cosmological framework those same kings brought with them, is Śrī Hari. In 1299, a Srivijayan prince named Sang Nila Utama landed on a peninsula at the tip of the Malay Archipelago and named his settlement Singapura, Siṃha-pura in the same Sanskrit naming convention that had already produced Śrī Laṅkā on an island seven hundred kilometres to the west. He was not independently discovering a concept. He was deploying a vocabulary that two thousand years of shared civilisational history had made the natural medium for political legitimacy across the Indian Ocean world.[12,13]

Any observer of the Sanskrit Indian Ocean record looking at this distribution would be compelled to one conclusion: Śrī was not the property of any people. It was the shared vocabulary of legitimacy in a connected civilisational sphere that encompassed Buddhist kingdoms, Hindu empires, Malay sultanates, and Telugu dynasties alike. This is not visible from inside any single national narrative, because every national narrative reaches for its own history and finds Śrī already there, and concludes it belongs to us. It belongs to all of them, and to none of them exclusively, for the same reason that no single nation owns the alphabet it writes in. The prefix marks participation in a civilisational order. That order preceded every modern identity that has since claimed it. [See Appendix II for the 1956 implications.][13,14]

The Lion-City Convention: Siṃha + Pura

Sanskrit Siṃha (lion) + pura (city) produces the lion-city compound deployed across the Indian Ocean world:[16,17]

Sinhapura: the Lala country, western India. Vijaya's birthplace per the Mahavamsa. The founding event and the founding city share the lion etymology: Sihabahu (lion-armed), Sihasivali, Sinhapura, Sinhala.

Singapura: modern Singapore, founded 1299 AD by Sang Nila Utama, a prince of the Srivijayan empire.[15]

The gap between these two deployments of the identical Sanskrit compound in the same Indian Ocean cultural sphere is approximately 1842 years. Lions were never native to the Malay Peninsula or Singapore island. The animal Sang Nila Utama reportedly saw was almost certainly a Malayan tiger.[15]

The lion identification was a conscious deployment of Sanskrit royal legitimacy vocabulary. Sang Nila Utama was not independently discovering the lion-city concept; he was a Srivijayan prince for whom this Sanskrit political toolkit was civilisational inheritance.

Srivijaya: The Transmission Vehicle

Srivijaya was the maritime empire centred in Sumatra that dominated Indian Ocean trade routes from the 7th to the 13th centuries AD.[16]

Its ruling elite was deeply Indianised: Sanskrit was the court language, both Hindu and Buddhist traditions were patronised, and Sanskrit political vocabulary permeated every dimension of its administrative apparatus. The Srivijayan empire controlled the Strait of Malacca and the trade routes connecting India, Southeast Asia, and China. It was the principal carrier of Indianised political culture into the Malay Archipelago.[16,17]

When Sang Nila Utama named his settlement Singapura, he was deploying naming conventions that 700 years of Srivijayan Sanskrit political culture had made entirely natural. The name Sri Lanka, the name Srivijaya, the name

Singapura, the name Sinhapura: these are all products of the same Sanskrit naming culture expressing political legitimacy across the Indian Ocean world.[13,16]

The Timeline of the Sanskrit Indian Ocean World

6th–5th c. BC	Sinhapura founded in the Lala country per the Mahavamsa tradition. Sanskrit lion-city compound first deployed in the island's founding genealogy.[6]
3rd c. BC	Ashokan inscriptions name the island Tambapanni. The name Sinhala, from Siṃhala, lion-people, begins appearing in external records.[17]
2nd c. AD	Ptolemy records Taprobane (from Tambapanni) as a known trading destination in his Geography. Roman merchants trading with the island.[17]
7th c. AD	Srivijaya empire founded in Sumatra. Sanskrit becomes the administrative language of a maritime empire controlling Indian Ocean trade routes.[16]
7th–13th c. AD	Srivijayan courts use Śrī as consecrating prefix continuously. Lion symbol appears in Srivijayan royal iconography. Theravada and Mahayana traditions both patronised.[13]
1299 AD	Sang Nila Utama, Srivijayan prince, founds Singapura. The Sanskrit lion-city compound, first deployed in Lala country some 1842 years earlier, is applied again by a prince for whom Sanskrit political vocabulary was civilisational mother tongue.[15]

This timeline demonstrates that Sinhapura and Singapura are not two isolated events with a striking etymological coincidence. They are two surviving, named instances within a continuous Sanskrit Indian Ocean political culture, a culture that produced Sri Lanka, Srivijaya, Singapura, and dozens of other Śrī-prefixed and Siṃha-rooted place names across a connected world spanning two millennia and ten thousand kilometres of coastline.

V. Vijaya and the Origin Question

The Bengal Misreading: How It Arose

The most widely circulated popular account of Vijaya's origins places him in Bengal, specifically the ancient kingdom of Vanga, corresponding roughly to modern West Bengal and Bangladesh. This reading was not derived from careful reading of the Mahavamsa. It was produced by 19th century colonial-era scholars, principally working through Turnour's 1837 English translation, who encountered the name Vanga in the text and mapped it onto the Bengal familiar to British administrative geography.[7]

Turnour knew no Pali when he began his work. He relied on Mahavihara monks as intermediaries. The Bengal reading he produced was therefore shaped both by his colonial geographic imagination and by the interpretive choices of his informants.[7]

The Bengal origin reading was subsequently absorbed into Sinhalese nationalist historiography because it served the founding mythology that a 19th-century racial-nationalist movement required. The question was never genuinely geographic. It was whether a state could be organised on the premise that its founding people arrived from a distant and racially distinct homeland, a premise that made ethnic hierarchy legible as historical destiny. Bengal, within the racial-linguistic imagination the Dharmapala movement had imported from Europe, provided the maximum distance the mythology needed. Gujarat did not. The reading was selected to serve the state-founding project, not derived from the text.[18]

The deeper problem is not which reading is correct; it is that any origin narrative became the basis for state architecture at all. Whether Vijaya sailed from Gujarat or Bengal is a question for historians. That his journey should determine who the modern state serves is the category error this document identifies.[18]

It must also be noted that the Indo-Aryan linguistic and cultural origin zone is the Indus-Saraswati basin: modern Punjab, Sindh, Haryana, and the northwest. That is the Vedic heartland. The Rigveda is geographically rooted in the Punjab and Sindh. Bengal was one of the later and more peripheral regions to be absorbed into the Vedic cultural sphere. Gujarat and Sindh are therefore geographically closer to the actual Indo-Aryan origin zone than Bengal is.[19]

What Geiger's Translation of Chapter 6 Actually Says

A direct reading of Chapter 6 in Geiger's 1912 translation reveals a genealogy considerably more complex than the Bengal origin theory presents.[6]

The chapter opens not with a Vanga princess but with the daughter of a Kalinga king, who was the consort of the Vanga king. It is this Kalinga-born queen's daughter, of Kalinga-Vanga mixed parentage, who encountered the lion. The encounter did not happen in Vanga. It happened in the Lala country, which the text specifies as where the lion attacked the caravan she had joined. The founding event is geographically located in Lala, not Bengal.

> *"In the Lala country a lion attacked the caravan in the forest, the other folk fled this way and that, but she fled along the way by which the lion had come."*[6]

From that union in Lala, Sihabahu was born. Sihabahu built Sihapura in the kingdom of Lala and ruled there. Vijaya was born in Sihapura. The text repeats the Lala designation in Chapter 7, in the Buddha's own dying words within the narrative:[6,20]

> *"Vijaya, son of king Sihabahu, is come to Lanka from the country of Lala, together with seven hundred followers."*[20]

Vanga is therefore not even Vijaya's grandmother's homeland with precision; it is one half of his great-grandmother's marital context, two full generations and one mythological event removed, and the text explicitly places the founding event geographically in Lala, not Bengal.

Identifying Lala

The Mahavamsa names Lala as the founding territory but does not itself locate Lala geographically. The identification of Lala with the Gujarat-Sindh coastal region is inference, drawn by combining the text's naming with external sources that independently establish where Lala was as a geographic designation. The inferential character of this identification must be stated clearly.[9,10]

External sources bearing on the location of Lala are as follows. Puranic geographic literature, the Mahabharata and the Vishnu Purana, lists Lata among the western coastal peoples of India, grouping it with regions associated with Gujarat and Sindh. It does not appear in Puranic enumerations of eastern or Bengali peoples.[21]

Xuanzang, travelling in the 7th century AD, placed a region he identified as Lata around modern Bharuch in southern Gujarat, an external geographic witness reflecting a name stable enough to have persisted for centuries.[8]

Ptolemy's 2nd century Geography names a region Larike on the western Indian coast in the same zone, drawing on Roman maritime trading knowledge predating the Mahavamsa entirely.[17]

The Rashtrakuta and Chalukya dynasties used Lata as a formal administrative designation for southern Gujarat across the 7th to 10th centuries, confirming geographic fixity, not mythological vagueness.[22]

None of these sources mention Vijaya or Sinhapura directly. What they collectively establish is that a place called Lala or Lata existed on the western coast of India in the Gujarat region, that this identification is stable across multiple independent traditions spanning several centuries, and that no equivalent evidence places a region called Lala or Lata in Bengal.[9,10]

Professor Barua has objected that a Gujarat origin requires demonstrable dialectical similarity between Gujarati and Sinhala that has not been established.[23]

Professor Chatterjee accepted the Gujarat identification on philological grounds.[22]

The question remains contested within South Asian scholarship. The document presents the Gujarat identification as the better-supported position on the available convergent evidence, not as established consensus.[29]

The Geography of the Landing

Before reaching Tambapanni, Vijaya first landed at Suppāraka on the western coast of India. Geiger's footnote identifies Suppāraka as Surparaka, modern Sopara in the Thana district, north of Bombay.[6,24]

Sopara's identity as ancient Suppāraka is independently corroborated by an Ashokan edict found at the site and by its appearance in multiple ancient maritime trading records as a major western Indian port.[24]

Vijaya departed from Suppāraka because his followers' violence caused danger there, and only then continued to Tambapanni on the northwest coast of Taprobane. Tambapanni is at Mannar, where the Palk Strait is approximately 30 kilometres wide and connects directly to the Tamil Nadu coast opposite Rameswaram, the natural crossing point for anyone travelling down the western coast of India.[6]

A departure from Bengal would require either an overland journey across the entire subcontinent or a maritime route around the southern tip of India. A Bengali maritime departure following natural monsoon routes and coastal geography would arrive on the eastern coast of the island, Trincomalee or Batticaloa, not Mannar. The landing site is the unguarded evidence in the text.

The Shramana Connection

Both Buddhism and Jainism emerge from the Shramana tradition, a non-Vedic philosophical stream whose geographic and cultural heartland was the Indus-Gangetic transition zone, western and central India.[25]

The Shramana tradition predates both Buddhism and Jainism as a recognisable philosophical stream. Its core commitments, ahimsa, rejection of Vedic ritual authority and Brahminical hierarchy, emphasis on individual renunciation, detailed monastic codes, are shared by both traditions in ways that cannot be explained by parallel development.[25]

Mahavira, the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism and a contemporary of the Buddha, operated within this same milieu. The historical concentration of Jain communities in Gujarat, Rajasthan, and the western Deccan reflects the western Indian rootedness of the Shramana philosophical tradition.[25]

Early Buddhist and Jain sculptural traditions share deep visual conventions: the seated meditative posture, the ushnisha cranial protrusion, specific hand mudras, the serene facial typology. These shared conventions are most pronounced in western Indian artistic traditions, the early schools associated with Gujarat, Mathura, and the western Deccan.[25]

If Lala was in the Gujarat-Sindh coastal zone, Vijaya's people would have departed from a region where the Shramana philosophical tradition was already deeply embedded. This provides an independent explanatory context

for why Buddhism found such rapid and deep adoption in Tambapanni following the founding period. This argument is circumstantial and inferential, a fourth converging dimension, not a proof.[25]

The Exile Narrative

The Mahavamsa states that Vijaya was exiled by his father Sinhabahu following disruptive behaviour, and that he arrived in Tambapanni as a consequence of that exile. This narrative cannot be independently verified. It exists only in the Mahavamsa and the Dipavamsa, both Mahavihara products. There is no Chinese, Roman, Puranic, or archaeological corroboration.[6,9]

The exile narrative performs several simultaneous functions within the text: it explains the small group (a prince arrived with 700 followers rather than an army); it legitimises the founding as a fresh beginning rather than conquest; and it provides a moral purification arc from disruptive prince to righteous founder.[26]

The 700 followers figure is suspicious as historical record. Round and symbolically resonant numbers in founding narratives are almost universally literary conventions, not census counts.[26]

The structural template is not unique to Tambapanni. Aeneas founds Rome after exile from Troy. Moses leads people out of Egypt to a promised land. Romulus and Remus are abandoned before founding. Exile preceding founding is one of the most universal mythological legitimacy patterns across cultures and centuries. Its presence in the Mahavamsa indicates the authors were working within a recognisable narrative tradition of legitimacy construction.[26]

VI. The Mahavamsa: Institutional Document, Not Ethnic Manifesto

The Real Competition

The 5th century context in Anuradhapura was not a conflict between Sinhalese and Tamil peoples. It was a conflict between two Buddhist monastic institutions: Mahavihara and Abhayagiri.[11]

Abhayagiri had for centuries received patronage from kings with Tamil associations, hosted diverse Buddhist traditions including Mahayana influences from South India and beyond, and represented a cosmopolitan vision of Buddhism that threatened Mahavihara's claim to exclusive custodianship of the Theravada tradition. That claim rests almost entirely on Mahavihara's own documents, a circularity the Mahavamsa has never escaped.[11]

The Mahavamsa tied royal authority to Mahavihara validation by constructing a sacred genealogy linking the Sinhalese kings to the Buddha's own ethnic world. This was not ethnic nationalism; it was institutional monopoly strategy.

The Pali Choice

Mahanama wrote in Pali, a liturgical language that no ordinary person in 5th century Anuradhapura spoke. This single fact dissolves any comparison between the Mahavamsa and Alfred's Anglo-Saxon Chronicle. Alfred wrote in Old English to reach common people and build popular identity. Mahanama wrote in the language of scholars and priests, for scholars, priests, and kings. The Mahavamsa was never intended as popular identity formation.[6]

The Elara Paradox

The Mahavamsa's treatment of King Elara, described as a just and noble ruler even as his removal is presented as necessary, reveals the text's own internal tension. The authors could not entirely erase the reality of a shared world in which a Tamil king's justice was acknowledged by Sinhalese subjects. The ethnic boundary the text constructs is visibly artificial even within its own pages.[6]

VII. The Colonial Transformation: How a Monastic Document Became an Ethnic Weapon

The Translation Chain

The Mahavamsa remained inaccessible outside monastic scholarship until the 19th century. Its transformation into an ethnic weapon required specific colonial interventions.[6,12]

1837: George Turnour, British civil servant, publishes the first English translation of the Mahavamsa. Turnour spent ten years on a text no European had previously made accessible, working through monastic intermediaries on a language he had to learn from scratch. The scholarly achievement was genuine and substantial. What must also be noted is that an academic project by a colonial administrator became the foundational act of modern Sinhalese ethnic historiography.[7]

1862 onwards: British colonial printing presses in Colombo make Sinhala-language publication possible at scale. The infrastructure for mass dissemination of a previously elite text was built by the coloniser.[12]

1877 onwards: Wilhelm Geiger applies Germanic Aryan philological frameworks to Sinhala. His framework carried racial hierarchy implications within the European academy of his time.[8]

1881: Pali Text Society founded in London, institutionalising the Mahavamsa as serious historical document.[6]

1908–1912: Geiger's German and English translations published.[6]

The Olcott Intervention

Colonel Henry Olcott arrived in Ceylon in 1880. His contribution to the survival of Buddhism on the island was real: he established Buddhist schools, defended Buddhist civil rights against colonial Christian privilege, and created an organisational infrastructure that gave lay Buddhists institutional voice for the first time. The Buddhist flag that flies across the island today is Olcott's design. These were consequential acts of solidarity by an outsider who invested decades of his life in a cause he believed in.[27]

What must also be observed is the intellectual framework he brought with him. He was a Freemason before becoming a Theosophist. Theosophy drew from the same Anglo-Protestant millennialist intellectual ecosystem that produced Christian Zionism. Both movements shared racial hierarchy frameworks, chosen people narratives transplanted onto new ethnic groups, and Western esoteric networks as transmission vehicles.[27]

The Buddhism Olcott promoted was structured around categories, racial purity, civilisational hierarchy, chosen custodianship, that had no precedent in Theravada tradition but strong precedent in the Protestant and esoteric milieu from which he came.[27]

Anagarika Dharmapala's Synthesis

Dharmapala, who explicitly described Sinhalese as a pure Aryan race in 1897, completed the synthesis.[18]

He fused Turnour's translation, Geiger's philology, and Olcott's racial-spiritual framework with the Mahavamsa's dynastic genealogy to produce something that had never existed before: Sinhalese Buddhist ethnic nationalism.[12,13]

What the intellectual history reveals, and this is visible only from outside the nationalist narrative itself, is that the construction had no indigenous materials. Its components arrived from Europe: racial hierarchy theory from German philology, chosen-people mythology from Protestant millennialism, mass mobilisation techniques from Theosophical networks. The actors who deployed these materials were not deceiving anyone deliberately. They had absorbed the available intellectual toolkit of their era and applied it to local conditions with genuine conviction. What the historical record compels us to notice is the structural irony: the ideology that most forcefully claimed to protect indigenous identity from foreign contamination was assembled entirely from foreign intellectual imports.[18]

VIII. The Asymmetry of the Political Sequence

What explains the fact that two cultural mobilisations, occurring in the same century on the same island, in response to the same colonial pressure, produced such different political trajectories? The question is not rhetorical. The answer reveals something important about the structure of what followed. Arumuga Navalar's work beginning in 1843 was structurally different from the Sinhalese Buddhist revival.[28]

Navalar's project was the preservation of Saiva literary and ritual tradition against Christian missionary dismantling. It carried no racial purity claim. It made no political sovereignty demand. It was a defensive cultural preservation response to missionary aggression, oriented inward toward retention of classical tradition, not outward toward exclusion of others.[12,28]

The 20th century Tamil political mobilisation, the Federal Party, the 50/50 demand, the language rights movement, was primarily constitutional and linguistic in character. Its intensification followed the Sinhala Only Act of 1956, not the other way around. Treating these two trajectories as symmetrical parallel ethnic mobilisations obscures an asymmetry that the chronological evidence plainly shows.[12]

This is not a claim of Tamil innocence or Sinhalese guilt. It is a claim about the structure of the historical sequence. The constitutional Tamil political movement was responding to legislative exclusion through constitutional means, until those means were systematically closed by the 1972 removal of minority protections, at which point the conditions for armed resistance were created.[12]

IX. Toward a Single Identity: Tambapanni

The island needs a name that belongs to no ethnic group and predates all constructed identities. Tambapanni, the name used in Ashokan inscriptions in the 3rd century BC, by Ptolemy as Taprobane, by Roman traders, by Arab navigators as Serendib, is that name.[17,36]

It carries no Buddhist, Hindu, Sinhalese, or Tamil ideological content. It is the island's identity in every external contemporary record from antiquity. It is geographic and ancient.

What a Non-Projected Identity Looks Like

The island's actual historical identity, when the post-Westphalian and colonial lenses are removed, is not one of two separate peoples in ancient conflict. It is a civilisation that developed at the intersection of maritime trade routes, monsoon agriculture, and multiple linguistic and cultural currents flowing across the Indian Ocean and the subcontinent.[5,20]

The hydraulic civilisation, the tank systems, the irrigation networks, was built by labour and engineering knowledge that crossed what we now call ethnic lines. The Buddhist monuments were patronised by kings of multiple linguistic backgrounds. The Palk Strait was not a border that divided two nations. It was the central highway of a connected civilisation.[11]

The Nayak Kings: A South Indian Dynasty at the Heart of Sinhala Buddhism

The most concentrated proof of that integrated civilisation is also the most recent. The last four kings of the last free kingdom on the island, the Kingdom of Kandy, which held out against Portuguese and Dutch colonialism for over two centuries, were not Sinhalese. They were Telugu-speaking Hindus from the Nayak royal families of South India. They are known as the Kandyan Nayaks, a cadet branch of the Madurai Nayak dynasty, descended from the Vijayanagara governors of Telugu Balija origin who had governed parts of South India since the 14th century. They ruled Kandy from 1739 to 1815. They became the greatest patrons of Theravada Buddhism in the island's modern history.

The transition to the Nayak line was not a conquest. It was a succession. When King Sri Veera Parakrama Narendrasinha, the last Sinhalese king of the Kandyan line, died in 1739 without a legitimate heir from his Madurai queen, he had already nominated his queen's brother as his successor, in accordance with the matrilineal succession law then operative. The man who became King Sri Vijaya Rajasinha had lived in the Kandyan palace since his sister's marriage to the king. He was, in every practical sense, already part of the court. His Tamil and Telugu origin was known, unremarkable, and legally irrelevant to the succession.

The four kings and their origins:

King	Reign	Origin and principal acts
Sri Vijaya Rajasinha	1739–1747	Brother of the Madurai queen of the last Sinhalese king. Raised in the Kandyan court from the time of his sister's marriage. Succeeded by nomination under matrilineal law. Founded the Nayak line.
Kirti Sri Rajasinha	1747–1782	Came from Madurai as a child. The most consequential Buddhist patron of the era: invited the Siamese mission of 1753, which restored the higher ordination of monks (upasampada) that had died out on the island. Without this act, the Siam Nikaya, the dominant monastic order of modern Sri Lanka, would not exist.
Sri Rajadhi Rajasinha	1782–1798	Brother of Kirti Sri; came from Madurai as a child. Raised in the Malwatte Temple, learned Pali and Sanskrit, and became a poet. A lavish patron of Buddhism. Died childless in

		1798, leaving the succession open.
Sri Vikrama Rajasinha	1798–1815	Born Kannasamy Nayaka in Madurai, 1780. Nephew of Sri Rajadhi. Brought to Kandy at 18. Commissioned the Octagon (Paththirippuwa) of the Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic and Kandy Lake. Used Tamil alongside Sinhala as a court language. Deposed by the British under the Kandyan Convention, 2 March 1815. Died in exile at Vellore Fort, 30 January 1832. His royal standard became the current flag of Sri Lanka.

These four men, all of Telugu Balija origin and all practicing Shaivite Hindus, presided over one of the great periods of Theravada Buddhist revival on the island. The Siam Nikaya, the monastic order whose higher ordination had been extinct on the island for decades before Kirti Sri Rajasinha's Siamese mission, is the dominant order of Sinhalese Buddhism today. The inner shrine of the Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic, the holiest site in Sinhalese Buddhist practice, was built by these kings. The Octagon commissioned by the last of them is described as the most admired symbol of Kandyan Sinhalese architecture. The flag that flies over the modern Sri Lankan state carries the lion standard of a Telugu prince from Madurai.

The court language of the Kandyan kingdom under the Nayaks was Tamil alongside Sinhala. The kings spoke Telugu natively. Their nobles signed the Kandyan Convention, the 1815 treaty that ceded the kingdom to the British, in Tamil. The descendants of Sri Rajadhi Rajasinha live today in Andhra Pradesh and Chittoor District, Tamil Nadu.

None of this was experienced as contradiction in the 18th century. The Kandyan aristocracy did not accept the Nayak kings despite their South Indian origin. They accepted them, initially, because their South Indian origin placed them above local factional rivalries. A Telugu Hindu from Madurai had no Kandyan clan to favour, no provincial patronage network to reward. That made him, paradoxically, more acceptable as a neutral sovereign than any local candidate would have been. The identity categories that would later be constructed as ancient and primordial, Sinhalese, Tamil, Buddhist, Hindu, as fixed and opposing essences, did not operate that way in the actual political culture of the kingdom. They were attributes people held simultaneously, navigated practically, and combined without crisis.

The Manufactured Rupture

The rupture, the sense of two ancient peoples in irreconcilable opposition, was not ancient. It was manufactured in the 19th century from European intellectual materials, hardened by British colonial administrative classification, and then detonated into political violence in the 20th century by actors on both sides who had internalised those colonial categories as primordial truth.[12]

Understanding this does not resolve the political questions of the present. But it dissolves the false historical foundation on which those questions have been built: the claim that the ethnic conflict expresses an ancient and inevitable incompatibility between two peoples who have always been separate and opposed.

They were not separate. They were one civilisation with internal diversity, as all civilisations have been.

Understanding this is not the end of the argument. It is the beginning of a different one. If the division was manufactured, it can be unmade, not by nostalgia for a unified past, but by building the institutional conditions under which a genuinely impartial civic state becomes possible. What those conditions look like in the context of the

macroeconomic opportunities now opening, the reorientation of global manufacturing capacity, the outsourcing and consumption model that small island economies are positioned to exploit, and the specific institutional design that professional policy making without patronage politics requires, is the subject of a companion paper: [3,5]

> *Tambapanni Positioned: A Strategic Framework for State Building and Macroeconomic Opportunity.*

The historical argument made here is the necessary precondition for that economic argument. You cannot build the right state if you do not first understand why the current one was built wrong.

The soil stained their hands copper.

That is all the Mahavamsa says about Tambapanni.

The rest is interpretation.

Glossary

This glossary defines specialist historical, linguistic, and methodological terms used in this document, as well as all abbreviations. Terms appear in the order most useful for a reader new to the subject matter. Abbreviations are listed alphabetically.

Historical and Specialist Terms

Tambapanni	The pre-colonial name for the island known today as Sri Lanka --- *Used in Ashokan inscriptions (3rd century BC); rendered as Taprobane by Ptolemy (c. 150 AD) and Roman geographers; as Serendib by Arab navigators. Carries no ethnic, religious, or political content. Used throughout this document as a historiographic designation, not a prescription for renaming the modern state.*
Taprobane	Greek and Latin name for Tambapanni, from Ptolemy's Geographia (c. 150 AD) --- *The name used by Greek, Roman, and later European sources for the island. Derived from the Pali/Sanskrit Tambapanni.*
Serendib	Arab navigators' name for the island, from which the English word 'serendipity' derives --- *Used in Arabic maritime and geographical literature from approximately the 7th century AD.*
Mahavamsa	Literally: The Great Chronicle --- *A chronicle of Sri Lankan royal dynasties and Buddhist institutional history, compiled in Pali by the monk Mahanama in approximately the 5th or 6th century AD. No undisputed autograph manuscript exists. The text is known through monastic manuscript copies and two major English translations: Turnour (1837) and Geiger (1912).*
Dipavamsa	Literally: The Chronicle of the Island --- *An earlier Pali chronicle, predating the Mahavamsa by approximately two centuries. Less literary but considered by some scholars to be closer to an earlier source tradition.*
Pali	The liturgical and scholarly language of Theravada Buddhism --- *An Indo-Aryan language closely related to Sanskrit. The Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa are both composed in Pali. Not a spoken vernacular language; used exclusively in a religious and scholarly context.*
Theravada	Literally: The Teaching of the Elders --- *One of the oldest surviving schools of Buddhism; the dominant tradition in Sri Lanka, Thailand, Myanmar, Cambodia, and Laos. The Mahavamsa is a Theravada institutional document.*

Mahavihara	Literally: The Great Monastery --- *The principal Theravada monastic establishment in Anuradhapura. The Mahavamsa was compiled within the Mahavihara tradition. The chronicle's perspective consistently favours Mahavihara institutional interests against rival Buddhist schools (Abhayagiri, Jetavana).*
Anuradhapura	The ancient capital of the island, approximately 200 kilometres north of Colombo --- *Served as the island's primary administrative and religious centre for over a millennium, roughly 4th century BC to 10th century AD. The Mahavamsa covers principally the Anuradhapura period.*
Vijaya	The legendary founder-king of the Sinhalese dynasty in the Mahavamsa narrative --- *Described in Chapter 6 as arriving from the country of Lala (north-western India, not Bengal) on the day of the Buddha's death. This document argues the standard 'Bengal origin' reading is a translation error introduced by Turnour and perpetuated by Geiger's footnotes.*
Lala / Lāṭa	The country named in Mahavamsa Chapter 6 as Vijaya's origin --- *Modern scholarly consensus places Lāṭa in the Saurashtra/Gujarat region of north-western India, not Bengal. The Bengal reading originates in a mistranslation by Turnour (1837).*
Shramana	A class of non-Brahminical Indian renunciants and wandering ascetics --- *Includes Buddhists, Jains, and Ajivika practitioners. The Shramana tradition was a major cultural transmission vehicle across Indian Ocean trading networks. Vijaya's group showed Shramana cultural markers, indicating connection to pan-Indian renunciant networks rather than Brahminical Aryan culture.*
Sanskrit	The classical literary and religious language of South Asia --- *An Indo-Aryan language; the prestige literary medium of Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain scholarship across South and Southeast Asia. The Sanskrit Indian Ocean World (c. 100–1400 AD) refers to the cultural and commercial network in which Sanskrit prestige terminology circulated across the Indian Ocean.*
Srivijaya	A maritime Buddhist empire centred in Sumatra, c. 7th–13th century AD --- *The primary transmission vehicle for Sanskrit Indian Ocean cultural conventions (the Śrī prefix, the Siṃha-pura lion-city naming convention) from South Asia to Southeast Asia. The name Singapore (Siṃhapura → Singapura) is a Srivijaya-era coinage.*
Palk Strait Zone	The shallow maritime corridor between Tambapanni and the south-eastern tip of the Indian subcontinent --- *Not a barrier between two civilisations but a highway between them. Pre-colonial movement across this corridor was continuous, seasonal, and bilateral. The 'Tamil invasion' framework commits the anachronism of treating this corridor as a border.*
Aryan (philological)	A 19th-century European linguistic classification denoting Indo-European language speakers --- *Originally a linguistic category (Indo-European/Indo-Aryan speakers), applied by Geiger and his contemporaries to imply racial hierarchy. The racial dimension of the term is now rejected by modern scholarship. Its survival in Sinhalese Buddhist nationalist discourse is a direct inheritance from the 19th-century European philological tradition.*
Westphalian framework	The system of sovereign territorial nation-states originating in the Peace of Westphalia (1648) --- *Imposes fixed territorial boundaries, mutually exclusive ethnic identities, and the concept of national sovereignty onto pre-modern societies that operated on entirely different political logics. Applying Westphalian categories to pre-modern Tambapanni is the central 'lens problem' this document identifies.*
Patronage state	A state apparatus organised around the distribution of resources, employment, and contracts to political supporters rather than on the basis of merit and rule of law --- *Fukuyama's term for the outcome when democratic competition precedes the construction of a professional impartial state. The argument in this document is that Sri Lanka became a patronage state because it democratised before it institutionalised.*
Donoughmore Constitution	The Sri Lankan constitutional framework introduced under the recommendations of the Donoughmore Commission (1928) --- *Introduced universal suffrage in 1931, before*

	independence, before a professional civil service existed, and before the rule of law was established as binding on political actors. This is the Fukuyama sequencing failure: democratisation preceding state-building.

Abbreviations and Short Forms

AD	Anno Domini (Latin: In the year of the Lord) --- *Calendar notation for years after the conventional date of Christ's birth. Equivalent to CE (Common Era). Used throughout for historical dating.*
BC	Before Christ --- *Calendar notation for years before the conventional date of Christ's birth. Equivalent to BCE (Before Common Era).*
ORCID	Open Researcher and Contributor Identifier --- *A persistent digital identifier for academic authors. The author's ORCID is 0009-0004-9181-2270 (orcid.org/0009-0004-9181-2270).*
Pali Text Society	An academic society founded in London in 1881 --- *Dedicated to the publication of Pali texts and their translation into Western languages. Published Geiger's canonical 1912 English translation of the Mahavamsa, which is the standard scholarly reference.*

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[33] Bandarage, A. / e-ir.info (2012). "Sri Lanka: Ethnic Conflict and the Rise of a Violent Secessionist Movement." e-ir.info/2012/11/28. [Documents Bandaranaike's 1956 campaign promise to implement Sinhala Only "within 24 hours"; the forcing of UNP leader Kotelawala, who had repeatedly pledged parity, to abandon that position under electoral pressure; and the structural dynamic by which each party escalated to outbid the other with no institutional constraint available.]

[34] Sinhala Only Act (2026). Wikipedia. en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sinhala_Only_Act. [Records the 1956 civil service composition: 30% of Ceylon administrative service, 50% of clerical service, 60% of engineers and doctors, and 40% of armed forces were Tamil. Also documents Bandaranaike's own 1944 position in favour of linguistic parity, his party's 1952 parity stance, and the 1955 shift to "Sinhala Only" as an electoral strategy that forced the UNP to abandon its own parity commitments.]

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[36] See Appendix I: The Etymology of Laṅkā.

Appendices

Appendix I: The Etymology of Laṅkā

On the etymology of Laṅkā. The name is almost certainly pre-Sanskrit, a toponym absorbed into the Sanskrit literary tradition rather than coined by it. Three points establish this. First, morphological: Sanskrit word formation is systematic and traceable through Pāṇini's grammar. Laṅkā does not decompose into a Sanskrit root plus suffix in any regular way. The proposed derivation from *laṅgh-* (to leap, to cross) fails phonologically; from that root one would expect *laṅghā* or *laṅghana*, not *laṅkā*, and is in any case almost certainly folk etymology generated retroactively by the Rāmāyaṇa narrative of Hanuman's leap. Monier-Williams lists *laṅkā* primarily as a proper noun without independent Sanskrit semantic content, which is the diagnostic pattern for a loanword absorbed as a place name. Second, the Rāmāyaṇa attests the name from roughly the 5th–4th century BCE but never glosses it. Laṅkā is simply received as Rāvaṇa's fortress, without explanation, which is consistent with the name being already known to the audience rather than coined by the text. Third, and most telling: the *laṅk-* root distributes across a geography that cannot be explained by Sanskrit literary borrowing alone. It appears as a generic term for elevated land or island across South Asian place names independently of the epic (Lanka in Nepal; multiple Lanka-rooted

names in peninsular Indian geography). More significantly, it appears in the ancient Malay kingdom of Langkasuka, recorded in Chinese sources as "Langgasu" from as early as the 1st century AD, well before the main period of Sanskritic Indianisation of the Malay Peninsula, and in Langkawi itself, which 16th-century maps record variously as Langa, Langka, and Langapura. The popular etymologies for Langkawi (helang + kawi; or Sanskrit langka meaning beautiful + wi meaning many) are themselves folk etymologies of the same kind as the laṅgh- proposal. This distribution pattern, across South Asia, the Subcontinent's interior geography, and the early Malay world independently, suggests a substrate root, possibly Austroasiatic, predating both Sanskrit and its Indianisation of Southeast Asia. Tamil Ilaṅkai (இலங்கை) is a Tamil morphological adaptation of the received name, il- (nominal prefix) + laṅk- (borrowed root) + -ai (Tamil nominal suffix), not a parallel cognate from a shared substrate; it confirms that the name was borrowed into Tamil, not that Tamil was its origin. See: Monier-Williams, M. (1899). A Sanskrit-English Dictionary. Clarendon Press; Burrow, T. and Emeneau, M.B. (1984). A Dravidian Etymological Dictionary (2nd ed.). Clarendon Press; Wikipedia: Lanka, Langkawi, Langkasuka.

Appendix II: The 1956 Number Plate and What It Reveals

In 1956 the government mandated the Sinhala script character ශ්‍රී on every vehicle number plate in the country, replacing the letter plates derived from the colonial name CEYLON. The stated motivation was cultural decolonisation: the recovery of indigenous identity from the English-language administrative culture that independence had not yet displaced. The actual motivation the data reveals is more specific. Tamil-speaking people, 29% of the population, held 30% of the Ceylon administrative service, 50% of the clerical service, 60% of the engineers and doctors, and 40% of the armed forces: a legacy not of favouritism but of missionary schools in the north that had provided English-medium education a generation earlier. Government employment was the primary route to middle-class stability in a non-industrialised economy. The battle over language was, at its base, a battle over who could compete for those positions. The ශ්‍රී on every vehicle was a signal that the democratic system had delivered. [30][31][34]

What made the sequence irreversible was structural. Bandaranaike had defended linguistic parity in 1944, arguing it would be "ungenerous on our part as Sinhalese not to give due recognition to the Tamil language", and his party held the parity position in 1952. By 1955 the competitive logic of democratic elections had changed the calculation entirely. His party broke from parity to campaign on "Sinhala Only"; this forced the ruling UNP, whose leader had repeatedly pledged not to abandon parity, to match the position or lose Sinhalese votes to a rival who would. The promise Bandaranaike made was to implement it within twenty-four hours of taking office. Both parties were now locked into a position neither had held three years earlier, not because the underlying situation had changed, but because each was rationally responding to the other's move in a system with no institutional constraint on what a majority could demand. Political scientists call this ethnic outbidding. It is the predictable output of democratic competition operating before a strong impartial state exists to define what democracy is permitted to do, which is precisely the Fukuyama sequencing failure this document argues was the island's foundational institutional error. As W. Edwards Deming observed: a bad system will beat a good person every time. Bandaranaike in 1944 was, on this question, a good person; he held the right position. The system beat him. [33][35]

By December 1956 the Federal Party had launched the anti-Sri campaign: vehicles in the north had the character tarred over, replaced with the Tamil shri, or substituted with Roman lettering. By early 1958 the confrontation had produced deaths. The B-C Pact that might have broken the sequence was abrogated, Bandaranaike tearing up his own agreement before monks who cheered, because the outbidding mechanism made honouring it politically fatal. A symbol placed on every vehicle to signal electoral delivery had become the mechanism through which its consequences were contested in blood. [12][32][34]

What the actors of 1956 could not have seen from inside their own moment, but what the longer view makes available, is the character of the symbol itself. The Śrī prefix was the most widely distributed political honorific in

two thousand years of Indian Ocean civilisation. It appears on the Kandyan kingdom's own kings, Sri Vijaya Rajasinha, Kirti Sri Rajasinha, Sri Rajadhi Rajasinha, Sri Vikrama Rajasinha, the four Telugu Hindu rulers from Madurai whose patronage built the inner shrine of the Temple of the Sacred Tooth. It names Srivijaya, the maritime empire whose Sanskrit political culture seeded the entire Archipelago. And in 1299, a Srivijayan prince named Sang Nila Utama, landing on a peninsula at the tip of the Malay world, reached for the same toolkit, naming his settlement Singapura, Siṃha-pura, in the same Sanskrit naming convention that had produced Sinhapura in the Lala country, that had produced Śrī Laṅkā, that was, in short, the civilisational common tongue of the entire Indian Ocean world. The symbol chosen to mark the island's distinctness from the subcontinent was the most eloquent available testimony to its embeddedness within it. The assertion of unique identity and the evidence of shared civilisation were, in this instance, the same character. And the conflict it generated was not a clash of two ancient peoples. It was the structural output of a democratic system that had never been given the institutional architecture to constrain what a majority could do with its majority. [15][16][30][34]